

First Research Reflection (09/15)

This first reflection is after completing a chunk of more organized and concentrated research after proposal acceptance. This reflection will illustrate some commonalities and themes that are emerging in this initial research period, and how they will direct me and my further inquiry. I found inadequacies in the physical, emotional and social realm of senior-technology interaction.

Some predictable common issues arose in my research, as many older adults found modern technology complex, frustratingly non-static, and inaccessible to those with visual impairment issues—and many seniors expressed a desire for simpler systems. Additionally, caregiver—or tech “Proxies” —support was an apparent institutional identified issue, as tech-support is often incredibly time consuming, which adds more to the responsibilities of family and non-family caregivers. This is not to mention that many caregivers may have their own blind spots when it comes to technology, which can only lead to more personal frustration in these important relationships. Scam and online fraud was also an expressed concern on the individual and institutional level, as organizations like the AARP have held local meetings about online fraud avoidance and protection, while seniors’ concern over malicious software viruses has led to decreased use of internet technologies.

Generally, there is a prevalent lack of and need for digital literacy skills to be taught and addressed. An interesting approach to this digital divide was through a simple tablet application, that while only able to send voice messages, photos and videos, gave some technological agency to those who could only use the main application whilst simultaneously familiarizing those with less tech skills but willing to greater engage with technology with the utilization of the tablet through the app, and facilitated further usage—as some participants chose to continue using the tablet for other internet-based activities.

This methodology also addresses a prevalent issue with senior use of technology which is the lack of confidence. Scared to break devices, get viruses, or feeling too “old for technology,” seniors (along with their impatient family members) believe themselves unable to interface with new technology. This creates a negative feedback loop, as seniors are not provided with the opportunity to engage with technology in a non-discouraging environment.

My goals and focuses reflecting this initial research will be understanding senior caregiver networks, and getting a better picture of their role as technology middlemen, and the unique struggles that arise in that venture. Additionally, I want to research methodology in introducing technology to seniors in a way that is efficient, useful and personal. I plan on familiarizing myself with more technical details of how scams are carried out, and the ways that people's data travels into scam networks, and how personal data can be better protected.

A concern that arises from this initial research is how my role will exist in-between institutional problem-solving approaches, which may be more focused on creating and directing resources, and the individual approach that will be more practical for me to execute.

Works Consulted

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